



Automated Processes vs. Agentic Workflows

Two operating models for getting work done — and why they age differently

 AUTOMATED PROCESSES		 AGENTIC WORKFLOWS
A human designs every step up front — the logic is fixed at build time.	01 ARCHITECTURE	The system composes its own steps at run time, inside human-set goals and guardrails.
Stagnant. The same logic runs until a person edits it.	02 TRAJECTORY	Compounding. Memory and refined instructions make each run better than the last.
Can't see its own errors — needs a human to audit and reprogram it.	03 SELF-CORRECTION	Evaluates its own output against the goal and adjusts mid-run.
Deterministic rules and branches: if X, then Y. No judgment.	04 DECISION LOGIC	Reasons through ambiguity, tradeoffs, and novel situations.
Breaks, or routes to a human queue, on anything outside the defined path.	05 EDGE CASES	Reasons through unanticipated cases in real time, or flags and asks.
Owned by developers — change requests, sprints, redeploys.	06 MAINTENANCE	Owned by light human steering — update an instruction or memory, not code.
Needs structured, predictable input: a form, a fixed file format.	07 INPUT TOLERANCE	Reads messy, unstructured input and interprets intent.
Predictable but brittle — fails the same way, every time.	08 FAILURE MODE	Resilient but evolving — failure modes shift as the system learns.
Lighter once built — fixed logic is easy to audit line by line.	09 GOVERNANCE	Heavier, ongoing — needs monitoring, cost tracking, and eval discipline.